

sports CRICKET

THE ART OF THE TURNAROUND

India's Test series win against England—the first there in 21 years—proves that there is a foundation for the future

■ By Sharda Ugra in London

Sachin Tendulkar came through the glass doors that separate the Marriott Hotel from the London County Hall at Westminster ahead of the rest and the usually quiet voice of this reticent, unusual batsman was the loudest in the hush of the lobby. He was still dressed in white, his face glowing with sweat and celebration and his eyes were shining. "This is the greatest day in my career of 18 years..." he said at a volume at which he is never heard to speak in. Then there was an even louder, un-Tendulkar-esque hiss of "Yesssss."

Yes. It is finally done. A series victory in England after 21 years has fulfilled an unspoken mission amongst players with whom Tendulkar has spent the last decade—to be a better team overseas, to win on foreign shores. In the last seven years, India have won more overseas Tests than any other country barring Australia. In the last 12 months, they have won two series outside the subcontinent, in the West Indies and England. This victory, over a team unbeaten at home since 2001, has quelled a few myths, comforted disgruntled fans and hyper anxious marketing men, and reverted a slide that had begun in late 2006, ending in the team's cataclysmic exit from the World Cup in the Caribbean.

India arrived in England to a tepid reception and a tatty reputation. Former England captain Michael Atherton did concede that India's captain Rahul Dravid "seemed the acceptable face of Indian cricket" but the others, resident punditry concurred, were just a rabble. Bad travellers, self-absorbed superstars, erratic bowlers, over the hill "bottom-feeding" bats-



PERFECT FINALE: Indian players celebrate after winning a historic Test series